staged a protest with several days of nonstop drumming against the suppression of the Chinese democracy movement. The Stasi had already broken up three other demonstrations outside the Chinese embassy by force (secret reports decided that the nerves of protestors were getting more frayed).

As if all this were not bad enough, US President George Bush called for the razing of the Berlin Wall in June, while appealing to the SED to bring glasnost to East Berlin. His call encouraged waves of refugees leaving the GDR for Austria via Hungary. At the same time, copying earlier tactics, more than 150 would-be GDR emigrants were holed-up in several West German diplomatic missions in the Eastern Bloc, hoping authorities would let them travel to the West.

Amid all this, Honecker's health took a sudden turn for the worse at a Warsaw Pact summit in Bucharest. Writhing in agony, doctors diagnosed a bout of bilious colic. He later recounted:

There was the possibility of an operation on me there and then, but they refrained from that and in accordance with my wish, I came back to Berlin by air. At the time it was very hot and during the whole time on the plane as well as in the ambulance from the airport to my house, I had to lie with an ice pack on my stomach to alleviate the pain.12

From this point, Honecker dropped from sight.

Crippled by abdominal pangs, he spent from July to September recovering from surgery to remove his inflamed gallbladder and part of his colon. Medical reports show complications occurred during the operation when his blood pressure dropped off dangerously. He was often confused and disorientated and displayed symptoms of atherosclerosis, a thickening of the arteries. Urologist Peter Althaus later revealed that surgeons left a suspected carcinogenic nodule in Honecker's right kidney due to his weak condition and failed to inform the patient of the suspected cancer.13